

Carry Out Group Based HTTP Basic Authentication in Nginx

This tutorial explains how to configure group based HTTP Basic authentication in Nginx using a programming language called Lua, which is supported by Nginx.



If you have ever used HTTP Basic authentication in Apache extensively and then, for some reason, migrated to Nginx, you are probably missing the group based filter that Apache has for this functionality. I was using Apache till now, but recently had to shift to Nginx for performance reasons. And I found this feature missing in Nginx.

However, Nginx supports Lua, which is a programming language. And you can do pretty much anything with the power of Lua - it can be used to modify Nginx's behaviour in numerous ways. So I developed a simple solution for group based authentication in Lua.

Before I move on to the Nginx part, let's first recall how group based authentication was configured in Apache:

```
<Location /foo>  
    AuthType Basic
```

```
AuthName Restricted  
AuthBasicProvider file  
AuthUserFile /etc/apache2/htpasswd  
AuthGroupFile /etc/apache2/groups  
Require group somegroup  
</Location>
```

You are basically telling Apache to use the file `/etc/apache2/htpasswd` to look up user names and passwords and the group membership in `/etc/apache2/groups`. The `htpasswd` file usually consists of something like what's shown below:

```
foo:$apr1$2xICHyAr$rbGe1q994Y3UKPhBoRwak.  
bar:$apr1$PvQ9Z65$7X98kYIpI/1nJik7jnSs1
```

And the group file consists of what follows: